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Who is the Neoliberal? Exploring Neoliberal Beliefs across East and West

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Research in political psychology has uncovered “elective affinities” between psychological traits and political ideology. Strong correlations have been found linking psychological variables to political-economic beliefs in Western countries. These results suggest that people’s psychological traits influence the development of their ideology, making some ideas, explanations, prescriptions, and ways of understanding the world seem more convincing or satisfying than others. Most such investigations have focused on differences along the liberal-conservative ideological spectrum in the United States, or the left–right divide in Europe and (the rest of) the Americas. Relatively little research has examined psychological elective affinities with neoliberal ideology in particular, and none to our knowledge has been done outside of the West (including Turkey), except for Israel. We report the results of a preliminary investigation into the psychological correlates of neoliberal ideology in Hong Kong, India, and the United States. Our U.S. results replicate earlier research introducing the Neoliberal Beliefs Index, whereas our Hong Kong and Indian results reveal similarities and differences in the psychological traits associated with neoliberal beliefs.

From inauspicious beginnings, neoliberalism has become a globally dominant political-economic ideology (Harvey, 2005). Although past research has revealed the structural and ideational factors behind neoliberalism’s rise (e.g., Blyth, 2002; Mudge, 2018), until recently little attention has been given to possible psychological contributors. For neoliberal ideology to spread so successfully, it would seemingly need not only a favorable political-economic environment and

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institutions devoted to promulgating it, but also resonance with psychological needs and dispositions. Other ideologies, such as conservatism and liberalism in the United States, have clear psychological correlates, suggesting that part of their success owes to their resonance with psychological needs and dispositions. Yet neoliberalism overlaps with both conservatism (e.g., minimal government regulation) and liberalism (e.g., open-border labor markets) in ways that contradict one another, making it *sui generis* and appropriate to be analyzed separately. In addition, research into elective affinities between psychological traits and ideology has focused on Western political contexts, leaving other regions with different ideological spectra unexplored (cf. Beattie, Chen, & Bettache, 2019). The present research investigates the psychological correlates of neoliberalism in the United States, replicating and extending prior research, and in two Asian contexts, India and Hong Kong, that differ from Western countries in some ways and are similar in others. We seek to understand the psychological needs and dispositions that may incline people toward adopting neoliberal beliefs in these three different political-economic and cultural contexts.

“Elective affinity” research suggests that our evolved psychology may include general dispositions that tend to lead us to support tradition and inequality (the psychological right) or change and equality (the psychological left) (Jost, Federico, & Napier, 2009; Jost, Nam, Amodio, & Van Bavel, 2014). An alternative conception depicts these dispositions as desires for protection from threat or freedom from oppression; leftwing economic views (e.g., social safety net and redistribution) correlate with rightwing social views (e.g., immigration restrictions) in public opinion surveys in most countries studied, because both promise protection from economic and cultural threats (cf. Azevedo, Jost, & Rothmund, 2019; Malka, Lelkes, & Soto, 2017). (Only when political discourse and institutions, such as parties and the media, package both rightwing social and economic positions together do the two correlate, as in the United States and some Western European societies.) Similarly, Jost, Glaser, Kruglanski, and Sulloway (2003) argued that political conservatism is a type of motivated social cognition because it stems from the need to avoid threatening and ambiguous stimuli. There is evidence that these basic psychological dispositions are partially heritable, with genes and the social and ideational environment jointly contributing to their development (Beattie, 2017).

Psychological dispositions related to political ideology may also extend to our sense of morality: The moral “senses” of fairness and care are more acute among the political left, whereas authority, loyalty, and sanctity are more acute on the political and religious right (Bettache, Hamamura, Amrani Idrissi, Amenyo, & Chiu, 2019; Graham, Haidt, & Nosek, 2009). Psychological traits that correlate with political ideology can be divided into epistemic and existential “motives” (Jost, 2017). Among epistemic motives, dogmatism, personal need for order and structure, need for cognitive closure, intolerance of ambiguity, and conscientiousness have been found to correlate with rightwing ideology,

whereas openness, cognitive reflection, and need for cognition have been found to correlate with leftwing ideology (Fatke, 2017; Jost, 2017). Among existential motives, threat sensitivity, fear of death, disgust sensitivity, attachment anxiety and avoidance, and a preference for cohesiveness (sociocultural “tightness”) have been found to correlate with rightwing ideology (Bettache & Chiu, 2019; Jost, Stern, Rule, & Sterling, 2017; Weber & Federico, 2007). The Schwartz values of universalism, stimulation, and benevolence correlate with leftwing ideology, and the values of security, conformity, tradition, and power correlate with rightwing ideology (Pioro, Schwartz, & Davidov, 2011). These studies have typically assessed conservative or rightwing and liberal or leftwing ideologies, sometimes with separate economic versus social components.

Bay-Cheng, Fitz, Alizaga, and Zucker (2015) have argued, however, that “it is critical for psychologists to assess [neoliberalism] as a distinct set of beliefs, despite its relation to and occasional intersection with other ideologies” (p. 83). Defining neoliberalism according to widespread social representations (commonly shared ideas, a zeitgeist, or political-economic “common sense”) about free, meritocratic market competition with minimal government intervention being the best way to organize society—as opposed to neoliberalism as a body of thought developed by intellectuals (e.g., Burgin, 2012; Mirowski, 2014)—they designed a Neoliberal Beliefs Inventory (NBI). The NBI was designed to detect elements of neoliberal ideology specific to the U.S. context, and the authors cautioned that neoliberalism’s foundations in rhetoric and values vary by culture, even while its policies are similar across borders. They noted that the system inequality subscale was particularly tied to the U.S. context, owing to four of its seven questions mentioning affirmative action. However, India has its own variant of affirmative action, the “reservation system,” and debate around it closely matches the debate in the United States (Deshpande, 2005). Mainland China also has a variant of affirmative action, *youhai zhengce*/优惠政策, although Hong Kong does not (Sautman, 1998). The remainder of the NBI, while tied to neoliberal ideology’s U.S. variant, evoking rhetoric and values of rugged individualism and the “self-made man,” has resonance in India (e.g., Ganguly-Scrase, 2003; Gopalakrishnan, 2006) and Hong Kong (e.g., Ngok, 2011; Yan, Cheung, Tsui, & Chu, 2017).

Since its publication, the article introducing the NBI has been cited nearly 20 times, but no research besides the original has used the scale to explore relationships between neoliberal ideology and psychological variables. Katz, Gravelin, and O’Brien (2018) found those scoring higher on the NBI were less sympathetic to an adolescent with an unintended pregnancy, and Medaglia, Yaden, Helion, and Haslam (2019) found no relationship between neoliberal beliefs and attitudes toward transcranial direct current stimulation, a technology presented as a means of self-improvement. The remainder of the articles citing the original NBI article refers to its discussion of neoliberalism without applying the NBI itself. Using a different scale of free market ideology as a proxy for

neoliberal beliefs, Sterling, Jost, and Pennycook (2016) found a relationship with “bullshit receptivity,” or acceptance of seemingly profound nonsense statements.

Given the paucity of research using the NBI, the only tests comparing it to psychological traits are found in the original article (Bay-Cheng et al., 2015). For instance, neoliberal beliefs were found to positively correlate with an internal locus of control, a sense of personal agency, and acceptance of victim-blaming views of rape; unsurprising relationships given neoliberalism’s emphasis on individual responsibility and the importance of personal growth through a commodification of the self (e.g., Han, 2017). Similarly, positive relationships between endorsement of neoliberalism and beliefs that the world is just, a view of social hierarchies as natural and justified, and right-wing authoritarianism—and negative relationships with feminist beliefs, engagement in collective action, and perceptions of sexism—were expected given neoliberal ideology’s view of free markets as productive of a meritocracy. In an ideal free market system producing a meritocracy, forms of prejudice (like sexism) would be weeded out for their inefficiency, and collective action would be superfluous.

Overview of Present Research

We are interested in the questions if and how neoliberalism, a globally dominant ideology, adapts itself to different cultural contexts. Do similar psychological profiles endorse neoliberalism across cultures? Bay-Cheng et al. (2015) showed that neoliberal beliefs in an individualist culture, the United States, correlated positively with psychological constructs that are individualist and self-focused in nature (e.g., internal locus of control). Is this also the case in non-Western, more traditionalist and collectivist societies? Or does neoliberalism thrive in diverging cultural contexts by aligning itself with culture-specific psychological profiles?

To begin exploring elective affinities between neoliberal ideology and psychological traits in varied cultural contexts, we selected Hong Kong, India, and the United States. The United States provides an opportunity to replicate some of Bay-Cheng et al.’s (2015) results and is an example of a Western, individualist, secular, low-context culture characterized by sociocultural looseness. India is an example of an Eastern, collectivist, high-context culture (or mix of cultures) characterized by sociocultural tightness, where secularism is in tension with religion; Hong Kong provides something of a midpoint between the two on these characteristics (e.g., Gelfand et al., 2011; Hofstede, 1980). Milton Friedman, an influential developer and apostle of neoliberal ideology, described Hong Kong as an “almost laboratory experiment in what happens when government is limited to its proper function” in his *Free to Choose* television series. Neoliberal values may be on the decline in Hong Kong, particularly among the young, as meritocratic outcomes seem less and less likely given an extreme concentration of wealth and political power (Ngok, 2011; Poon, 2011). In India, to the contrary, neoliberal policies are much newer,

having been implemented beginning in the late 1980s, and neoliberal values seem on the ascendant (Gopalakrishnan, 2006). Yet, India is one of the world's tightest societies and thus it is interesting to investigate how it embraces neoliberalism, a highly individualist ideology in the West. Additionally, similar colonial heritages of Hong Kong and India have resulted in widespread understanding of English, obviating the need for translation. Therefore, both societies offer ideal starting locations to test psychological links with neoliberal beliefs outside of the West.

Hypotheses

Neoliberalism, ideology, and morality. To replicate, extend, and compare the results of Bay-Cheng et al.'s (2015) research in two Asian contexts, Hong Kong and India, we also used Rotter's (1966) Internal–External (I–E) Control Scale and Ho et al.'s (2015) seven-question Social Dominance Orientation (SDO) Scale. SDO measures the belief that social hierarchies are natural and justified, which is in line with the neoliberal idea of competition in the free marketplace where success and failure are deemed personal responsibilities and thus the best deserve to be on top and those who fail deserve to be left behind (e.g., Azevedo et al., 2019; Perez & Salter, 2019). Hence, we expect SDO to positively relate to neoliberal beliefs across all three cultural contexts (Hypothesis 1a). We further expect that an internal locus of control, which posits that control over one's life outcomes lies within oneself independent of the (social) environment, positively relates to neoliberalism in the United States; however, in collectivist cultures, where the social context and mutual dependencies are essential to one's life outcomes, neoliberalism may navigate within the prevailing collectivist context by correlating less strongly with such individualist constructs (Hypothesis 1b). Therefore, these two measures, tested previously in the United States by Bay-Cheng et al. (2015), may provide an indication of how flexible neoliberal ideology has been as it crossed borders.

We expected both social and economic conservatism to be positively related to neoliberal beliefs in the United States—owing to discursive influences in the U.S. political context linking social and economic forms of conservatism to neoliberalism—but only economic conservatism to be related to neoliberal beliefs in Hong Kong and India (Hypothesis 2a). Furthermore, we expected the NBI to correlate with a preference for neoliberal policies and their common outcomes, that is, lower taxes, market provision of social services with a minimal government social safety net, and income and wealth inequality (Hypothesis 2b), and with a preference for economic over social benefits in a series of policy, personal, and business vignette-dilemmas (Hypothesis 2c). Additionally, when asked to respond to moral dilemmas balancing individual interest versus moral principle, we expected neoliberal beliefs to be positively correlated with giving preference to self-interest in deciding moral questions (Hypothesis 3). All these relationships are expected because neoliberal ideology promotes individual responsibility,

self-focus, and economic rationality, which should express itself in economic conservatism, and preferences for an unequal but presumably meritocratic society, economic over social ends, and self-privileging moral choices.

Neoliberalism and the self. We expected self-interest to positively relate to neoliberal beliefs; we had no prediction regarding prosocial other-interest, because an adherent of neoliberalism could be just as likely to believe that their ideology, implemented in policy, would benefit (by removing well-intended but harmful government intervention) or harm (by creating an equal playing field on which the strong dominate the weak) others (Hypothesis 4). Considering neoliberalism's individualistic, competitive, and meritocratic orientation, an ideology favoring the "best" or those viewing themselves as such, we expected it more likely to be assimilated by those higher in both narcissism and self-esteem (Hypothesis 5).

Neoliberalism, power, and in-/out-group relations. We expected neoliberal beliefs to positively correlate with agentic values—"getting ahead" or self-advancement in hierarchies—and to negatively correlate with communal values—"getting along" or maintaining social relationships—due to its strong focus on competition (Hypothesis 6). In line with this, we expected neoliberal beliefs to be positively related to insecure striving, attempting to move up in the world (Hypothesis 7), and higher self-placement on a "power ladder" indicating one's position in the socioeconomic hierarchy, because neoliberalism favors the advantaged as everyone deemed is responsible for their own fate, and hence the endorsement thereof should be more prevalent among those who consider themselves better off than others (Hypothesis 8). Despite the purportedly "color-blind" aspects of neoliberal meritocracy, we hypothesized that the NBI would positively correlate with a measure of preference for lighter skin tones among pools of hypothetical job applicants. We argue that this may be so because whiteness is in most if not all societies still intimately related to privilege, and, as mentioned before, neoliberalism favors the advantaged (Hypothesis 9a). We further expected neoliberal beliefs to positively correlate with a measure of identification with one's own ethnic group, because we were investigating mainly majority group members and a strong identification would suggest ethnocentric attitudes toward the dominant group (Hypothesis 9b). Finally, we tested whether neoliberal beliefs predicted a preference for either tight or loose social groups. Bettache and Chiu (2018; 2019) showed that conservatism predicted a preference to be part of a tight group among U.S. participants. The endorsement of neoliberal beliefs therefore could result in a break from this facet of conservatism, in keeping with neoliberalism's endorsement of individualism (Hypothesis 10).

Neoliberalism as a legitimizing ideology. Finally, we suspected that neoliberalism serves as a legitimizing ideology for people with an internal

locus of control—who believe that one’s life outcomes are determined by one’s own actions rather than environmental factors—and who therefore prefer a free market, low-tax society with higher inequality, because they imagine themselves (and others) uniquely capable of rising to the top, as long as one puts in the effort. Indeed, such an attitude is in line with neoliberal ideology that assigns full responsibility for success (and failures) to people themselves. Therefore, we expected that those with an internal locus of control would express a preference for an unequal society with low taxes and a minimal safety net, mediated by endorsement of neoliberalism (Hypothesis 11).

Method

Participants and Procedure

Undergraduate and graduate students from a university in Hong Kong ($N = 136$, after eliminating responses that failed attention checks) were recruited via a notice included in a university mass email. They completed the questionnaire for a chance to win one of eight HK\$200 prizes. Their average age was 21.2 years ($SD = 4.68$, range = 17–51); women comprised the majority (60.3%, $n = 82$) and men the minority (39.7%, $n = 54$). Most identified as East Asian (83.8%, $n = 114$), and the remainder identified as South Asian (8.8%, $n = 12$), White or Caucasian (5.1%, $n = 7$), or multiple ethnicity/other (2.2%, $n = 3$).

For India, we gathered data via Amazon Mechanical Turk ($n = 177$, after eliminating responses that failed attention checks). Participants’ average age was 27.98 years ($SD = 5.01$, range = 18–48); men comprised the majority (68.4%, $n = 121$) and women the minority (31.6%, $n = 56$). Most identified as South Asian (86.4%, $n = 153$), and the rest as East Asian (6.2%, $n = 11$) or other (7.3%, $n = 13$). The majority (69.5%, $n = 123$) reported having a bachelor’s degree, with fewer reporting having attained higher (27.2%, $n = 48$) or lower (3.4%, $n = 6$) academic qualifications. Indian participants were paid ₹35 each.

For the United States, we also gathered data via Amazon Mechanical Turk ($N = 202$, after eliminating responses that failed attention checks). U.S. participants’ average age was 36.26 years ($SD = 10.93$, range = 20–72); men comprised the majority (55%, $n = 111$) and women the minority (45%, $n = 91$). The majority identified as White or Caucasian (77.7%, $n = 157$), and the rest identified as Black or African American (8.4%, $n = 17$), Native American or American Indian (5.4%, $n = 11$), East Asian (2.5%, $n = 5$), Hispanic or Latino (2%, $n = 4$), or other (4%, $n = 8$). A plurality (41.6%, $n = 84$) reported having a bachelor’s degree, with fewer reporting having attained higher (30.2%, $n = 61$) or lower (28.2%, $n = 57$) academic qualifications. U.S. participants were paid US\$1 each.

All participants completed an online questionnaire that included the measures described below, in order of presentation.

Measures

Demographics and ethnic identification. We asked participants for their gender, ethnicity, level of education, and employment status. Identification with one's own ethnic group was measured with a single statement, "I identify with the people of my ethnicity." Agreement was measured on a scale of 1 (*Does not describe me*) to 5 (*Describes me very well*).

Political-economic beliefs and preferences. Political ideology was assessed using Everett's (2013) 12-item Social and Economic Conservatism Scale (SECS). The scale lists a range of social issues that are considered of relevance to conservatives and asks them how positive or negative they feel about each issue on a scale of 0 to 10, where 0 represented very negative, and 10 represented very positive. Examples of issues are religion, patriotism, and fiscal responsibility. (Hong Kong sample, $\alpha = .53$; Indian sample, $\alpha = .67$; U.S. sample, $\alpha = .88$.)

We assessed policy preferences by asking participants whether they preferred to live in a society with a relatively (un)equal income and wealth distribution, a high (low) tax rate, and a strong (minimal) social safety net providing healthcare, childcare, and pensions (vs. these being available for purchase in the marketplace). Participants' preference for social versus economic interests was assessed with six vignette-dilemmas, where the two response options represented a privileging of individual economic or social benefits (e.g., support or oppose an inheritance tax, make or refuse a donation to a refugee charity, and share or keep a windfall gain with an orphanage).

Social dominance orientation. To reduce survey length, we used Ho et al.'s (2015) seven-item SDO scale instead of the 16-item SDO for Others scale used by Bay-Cheng et al. (2015). An example item is "Some groups of people are simply inferior to other groups." Answers were measured on a scale of 1 (*Strongly oppose*) to 7 (*Strongly favor*). (Hong Kong sample, $\alpha = .66$; Indian sample, $\alpha = .41$; U.S. sample $\alpha = .85$.)

Neoliberal beliefs. We used Bay-Cheng et al.'s (2015) 25-item NBI to assess neoliberal ideology, excluding the four questions relating to affirmative action (the "reservation system" in India) in our analyses of the Hong Kong data. An example item is "People should be allowed to compete to ensure that the best person wins." Answers were measured on a five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (*Strongly disagree*) to 7 (*Strongly agree*). (Cronbach's alphas are reported in the "Results" section.)

Self-interest and other interest. We used Gerbasi and Prentice's (2013) 12-item Theories of Self–Other Relations (TSOR) scale that measures beliefs

about the appropriate relationship between self-interest and other interest across four subscales: a prosocial, other-interest relationship (e.g., “I am concerned with overall best interest for everyone”), and three forms of self-interest, a self-prioritizing relationship (e.g., “I look out for myself first, and then I try to make sure others are doing okay”), a self-comparative relationship (e.g., “I am concerned about doing as well or better than those around me”), and a self-maximizing relationship (e.g., “I only care about my interests”). Responses were provided on a scale of 1 (*Strongly disagree*) to 7 (*Strongly agree*). (Hong Kong sample, $\alpha = .63$; Indian sample, $\alpha = .85$; U.S. sample, $\alpha = .84$.)

Locus of control. A shorter version being unavailable, we used the 29-item I-E Control scale (Rotter, 1966). For every item, participants were asked to choose one of two options they agreed with the most, with one option corresponding to an internal locus of control and the other to an external locus of control. An example is “A. Many of the unhappy things in people’s lives are partly due to bad luck” (external locus of control, coded as “1”), or “B. People’s misfortunes result from the mistakes they make” (internal locus of control, coded as “0”). A lower score indicated an internal locus of control, and a higher score indicated an external locus of control.

Narcissism and self-esteem. We used Gentile et al.’s (2013) Narcissistic Personality Inventory-13 (NPI-13) to measure narcissism. For every item, participants were asked to choose one of two options they agreed with the most, with one option corresponding to narcissistic tendencies and the other opposing such tendencies. An example is “A. I find it easy to manipulate people.” (*Narcissism*), or “B. I don’t like it when I find myself manipulating people.” The 13 items were totaled for an overall score, along with subscales measuring Leadership/Authority (four items, e.g., “I have a strong will to power”), Grandiose Exhibitionism (five items, e.g., “I like to look at my body”), and Entitlement/Exploitativeness (four items, e.g., “I find it easy to manipulate people”).

Self-esteem was assessed using Robins, Hendin, and Trzesniewski’s (2001) single-item measure. Participants indicated to what extent they agreed with the statement, “I have high self-esteem,” on a scale of 1 (*Not very true of me*) to 7 (*Very true of me*).

Agentic and communal values. Trapnell and Paulhus’ (2012) 24-item Agentic and Communal Values (ACV) scale was used to assess participants’ focus on “getting ahead” versus “getting along.” Participants rated the importance of 24 values (e.g., tradition, power, and civility) on a scale of 1 (*Not important to me*) to 7 (*Highly important to me*). Cronbach’s alphas for agentic values were .88, .90, and .92, for the Hong Kong, Indian, and U.S. samples, respectively; for communal values, alphas were .88, .91, and .88.



Fig. 1. Snapshots from Bettache and Chiu's (2018) animated video. Group 1 is the cohesive group; Group 2 is the loose (uncohesive) group.

Moral dilemmas. We adopted six vignettes presenting participants with two options each. Each vignette pitted a moral principle against self-interest (e.g., risk losing one's job or withhold important information from a friend and save one's own life or risk it by helping others). Participants were asked to select the option that best suited how they would resolve the moral dilemma. An example is a vignette about a leaking lifeboat, where the participants had the option of staying in the lifeboat to help the others scoop out water to stay afloat, or jumping ship and boarding a sound lifeboat with one extra space.

Cohesiveness. Participants viewed Bettache and Chiu's (2018) individuated versus homogenized group animated video, which portrays one group of humanoid characters moving in lockstep and another moving in uncoordinated fashion. Participants were asked to report to which group they would want to belong, indicating a preference for "loose" or "tight" sociocultural groups (see Figure 1).

Skin tone preference. Participants were asked to imagine they were the manager of a company and had to select three candidates from a set of nine pictures (three light-skinned, three medium, and three dark-skinned individuals), after reading the following text:

Decisions in the worlds of business, law, education, medicine, and even more ordinary daily interactions between individuals, all rely on trust. Psychological research has shown that people can be very good at predicting other people's personality traits and behavior based on the impression they get from their face.

Imagine that you are the manager of a company and you are tasked with creating a team of individuals that you will work closely with for an upcoming project. Based on your first impression, you have to select three individuals out of a set of pictures. Please select three individuals from this FIRST set of applicants.

This selection process was repeated three times on three separate pages (i.e., three pages with nine pictures).

Power ladder. To measure perceived socioeconomic standing, we asked participants to place themselves on a power ladder (Adler, Epel, Castellazzo, & Ickovics, 2000), after reading the following instruction:

Think of this ladder as representing where people stand in our society. At the top of the ladder are the people who are the best off, those who have the most money, most education, and the best jobs. At the bottom are the people who are the worst off, those who have the least money, least education, and the worst jobs or no job. Indicate where on the ladder you feel you personally stand right now.

Striving to avoid inferiority. To measure insecure striving (and “secure non-striving”), we used Gilbert et al.’s (2007) 31-item Striving to Avoid Inferiority Scale (SIAS). An example item is “To be valued by others I have to strive to succeed.” Answers were measured on a scale of 1 (*Never*) to 7 (*Always*). The SIAS also includes three subscales measuring the reasons participants feel pressured to compete: Losing Out (three items, e.g., “If you don’t compete with others and succeed, you will not advance in life”), Being Overlooked (four items, e.g., “If you don’t compete with others and succeed, people will not take much interest in you”), and Active Rejection (four items, e.g., “If you don’t compete with others and succeed, others will push you away”), measured on a scale of 1 (*Don’t Agree*) to 10 (*Completely Agree*). Cronbach’s alphas for the SIAS overall for the Hong Kong, Indian, and U.S. samples, respectively, were .71, .92, and .91; for the Losing Out subscale, .87, .91, .91; for the Being Overlooked subscale, .86, .90, .94; and for the Active Rejection subscale, .94, .95, .96.

Results and Discussion

The Hong Kong, Indian, and U.S. samples were indistinguishable in their stated preferences for an unequal (vs. a more equal) society and in their responses to our moral questions; but for every other variable, at least two of the three possible comparisons differed to a significant degree (Table 1). Neoliberal beliefs were most strongly endorsed in India ($M = 3.99$, $SD = 0.46$), followed by the United States ($M = 3.61$, $SD = 0.83$), where there was also more heterogeneity in endorsement (our U.S. sample displayed the greatest heterogeneity in 70% of the single measures and subscales we used). Our Hong Kong student sample reported the lowest endorsement of neoliberal beliefs ($M = 3.13$, $SD = 0.43$), echoing Ngok’s (2011) analysis, while also reporting the highest external locus of control ($M = 13.10$, $SD = 3.93$). As would be expected given pervasive colorism in Indian society (e.g., Mishra, 2015), our Indian sample exhibited a significantly higher preference for lighter skin ($M = 0.60$, $SD = 0.49$) than our Hong Kong ($M = 0.31$, $SD = 0.47$) and U.S. ($M = .32$, $SD = 0.48$) samples (where social desirability bias may have influenced responses). Our Indian sample was also conspicuous in reporting the highest SDO ($M = 3.70$, $SD = 0.65$), followed by Hong Kong ($M = 3.22$, $SD = 0.80$) and the United States ($M = 3.05$, $SD = 1.26$); ethnic identification ($M = 4.06$, $SD = 0.71$), followed by the United States ($M = 3.58$, $SD = 0.83$) and Hong Kong ($M = 3.10$, $SD = 1.05$); narcissism ($M = 7.30$, $SD = 2.03$), followed by the United States ($M = 4.99$, $SD = 3.29$) and Hong Kong

Table 1. Mean Ratings by Country

	Ethnic identification (1–5)	SECS total (0–10)	SECS social (0–10)	SECS economic (0–10)	Inequality preference (0–1)	Social- economic preference (–6–6)	Morality: Self–other (–6–6)	NBI total (1–5)	NBI SI (1–5)	NBI C (1–5)	NBI PW (1–5)
Hong Kong	3.10 (1.1)	5.23 (0.86)	5.67 (1.2)	4.62 (1.1)	0.26 (0.44)	–1.13 (1.2)	2.77 (1.3)	3.13 (0.43)	2.72 (0.61)	3.87 (0.60)	3.04 (.71)
India	4.06 (0.71)	7.00 (0.95)	7.59 (1.2)	6.17 (1.1)	0.27 (0.44)	–2.21 (1.1)	2.80 (0.97)	3.99 (0.46)	3.85 (0.61)	4.13 (0.48)	4.09 (.52)
United States	3.58 (0.83)	6.34 (1.8)	6.55 (2.1)	6.04 (1.7)	0.23 (0.42)	–1.57 (1.5)	2.67 (1.1)	3.61 (0.83)	3.36 (1.2)	4.16 (0.59)	3.59 (1.0)
HK–IN,	***	***	***	***	∅	***	∅	***	***	***	***
HK–US,	***	***	***	***	∅	***	∅	***	***	***	***
IN–US	***	***	***	***	∅	***	∅	***	***	***	***

Note. Standard deviations are in parentheses; *p* values are reported in the last row of each group, for the Hong Kong–Indian (HK–IN), Hong Kong–United States (HK–US), and Indian–United States (IN–US) comparisons, in that order.
*** *p* < .001; ** *p* < .01; * *p* < .05; † *p* < .10; ∅ *p* > .10.

(Continued)

Table 1. Continued

	NBI GI (1-5)	SDO (1-7)	Locus of control I-E (0-23)	TSOR prosocial (1-7)	TSOR maximizing (1-7)	TSOR self- priority (1-7)	TSOR self- comparative (1-7)	NPI total (0-13)	NPI leadership (0-4)	NPI grandiose (0-5)	NPI entitlement (0-4)	Self- esteem (0-4)
Hong Kong	3.08 (0.64)	3.22 (0.80)	13.10 (3.9)	4.94 (0.73)	3.93 (0.85)	5.23 (0.87)	4.90 (0.84)	4.00 (2.7)	1.26 (1.2)	1.22 (1.2)	1.51 (1.2)	4.40 (1.3)
India	3.87 (0.69)	3.70 (0.65)	10.92 (2.6)	5.65 (0.79)	5.44 (0.95)	5.55 (0.83)	5.55 (0.85)	7.30 (2.0)	2.34 (0.99)	2.85 (1.2)	2.11 (1.1)	5.68 (1.0)
United States	3.44 (1.1)	3.05 (1.3)	11.07 (4.1)	5.33 (0.92)	4.34 (1.4)	5.12 (1.1)	4.79 (1.2)	4.99 (3.3)	1.70 (1.3)	1.80 (1.5)	1.49 (1.3)	5.11 (1.5)
HK-IN,	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***
HK-US,	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***
IN-US	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***	***

*** $p < .001$; ** $p < .01$; * $p < .05$; ^a $p < .10$; ^b $p > .10$. (Continued)

Table 1. Continued

	ACV agentic (1–9)	ACV communal (1–9)	SIAS insecure (0–4)	SIAS secure (0–4)	SIAS losing (1–10)	SIAS overlooked (1–10)	SIAS rejection (1–10)	Power ladder (1–8)	Skin preference (–3–3)	Cohesive group preference (0–1)
Hong Kong	6.03 (1.3)	6.64 (1.1)	2.29 (0.48)	2.27 (0.55)	6.15 (1.7)	5.85 (1.6)	4.86 (2.0)	4.57 (1.3)	0.30 (2.5)	0.31 (0.47)
India	7.40 (1.0)	7.55 (1.0)	2.79 (0.51)	2.68 (0.61)	6.38 (2.6)	6.53 (2.7)	6.22 (2.7)	6.20 (1.4)	1.45 (3.2)	0.60 (0.49)
United States	6.26 (1.6)	7.11 (1.2)	2.43 (0.75)	2.61 (0.66)	7.08 (2.1)	6.71 (2.3)	5.93 (2.7)	5.21 (1.7)	0.32 (2.7)	0.36 (0.48)
HK–IN, HK–US, IN–US	***, $\emptyset$, ***	*** $\emptyset$, ***	*** $\dagger$, ***	*** $\emptyset$, ***	$\emptyset$, ***	*** $\emptyset$, ***	*** $\emptyset$, ***	*** $\emptyset$, ***	*** $\emptyset$, ***	*** $\emptyset$, ***

*** $p < .001$; ** $p < .01$; * $p < .05$; $\dagger p < .10$; $\emptyset p > .10$.

($M = 3.70$, $SD = 2.66$); self-esteem ($M = 5.68$, $SD = 1.04$), followed by the United States ($M = 5.11$, $SD = 1.53$) and Hong Kong ($M = 4.40$, $SD = 1.34$); and the greatest preference for economic over social benefits ($M = -2.21$, $SD = 1.08$), followed by the United States ($M = -1.57$, $SD = 1.48$) and Hong Kong ($M = -1.13$, $SD = 1.17$).

Replication of Factor Structure and Scale Reliability of the NBI

We tested whether the factor structure as presented by Bay-Cheng et al. (2015) could be replicated with our data (see Table 2). Applying the same standards used by Bay-Cheng et al. (2015), three of four model fit indices (root-mean-square error of approximation [RMSE—the standard deviation of unexplained variance], standardized root-mean residual [SRMR—the standardized difference between an observed and predicted correlation], comparative fit index [CFI—a measure of discrepancy between the data and a hypothesized model adjusted for sample size], and a chi-square p value $< .05$) indicated an acceptable fit for all three samples; however, the CFI for our Hong Kong and Indian data failed to meet the threshold they used. (We eliminated the four affirmative action questions in the Hong Kong data; with them included, model fit indices suffered: an RMSE of .07, an SRMR of .09, a chi-square p value of $< .001$, and a CFI of .79.) A possible explanation for this is that some of the NBI items are both understood and endorsed differently in non-Western cultural contexts, something to which we return in the discussion.

Our U.S. sample had a Kaiser–Meyer–Olkin measure of sampling adequacy (MSA—an indicator of the proportion of variance caused by underlying factors) of .95, indicating a high level of shared variance, and the p value of a Bartlett’s test of sphericity (testing whether variables are unrelated and unsuitable for factor analysis) was significant at $< .001$ (indicating variable relatedness and suitability). The U.S. data had a Cronbach’s alpha of .96 for the NBI overall, and among subscales, .94 for System Inequality (SI), .75 for Competition (C), .94 for Personal Wherewithal (PW), and .91 for Government Interference (GI). (These were substantially similar to Bay-Cheng et al.’s [2015] results.)

Our Hong Kong sample had an adequate MSA of .76 (.77 without the affirmative action questions) and a Bartlett’s test of sphericity was significant at $< .001$. The Hong Kong data had an acceptable but lower Cronbach’s alpha of .83 (.81 without the four affirmative action items), and among subscales, .76 for SI, .73 for C, .81 for PW, and .75 for GI.

Our Indian sample had a relatively high MSA of .88 and a Bartlett’s test of sphericity was significant at $< .001$. The Indian data similarly had an acceptable Cronbach’s alpha of .90, and among subscales, .79 for SI, .60 for C, .80 for PW, and .79 for GI.

Table 2. Confirmatory Factor Analysis Results

Item	CFA loadings		
	United States	Hong Kong	India
Factor 1: System inequality			
Affirmative action is an outdated policy now that people are generally treated as equals.	.81	–	.56
Discrimination does not exist today to such a degree that affirmative action policies are necessary.	.86	–	.57
Affirmative action does not help eradicate discrimination. Instead it exacerbates it by promoting people on the basis of minority status instead of merit.	.79	–	.71
Affirmative action is a problem because it treats people unequally.	.78	–	.53
People who complain about discrimination are often just blaming other people for their own problems.	.85	.64	.59
I think people imagine more barriers, such as discrimination, than actually exist.	.88	.70	.64
Based on my own experience and the people around me, it's hard for me to feel sorry for people who complain about discrimination.	.88	.63	.58
Factor 2: Competition			
People should be allowed to compete to ensure that the best person wins.	.69	.66	.60
Being competitive is part of human nature.	.60	.70	.50
Competition is a good way to discover and motivate the best people.	.74	.73	.50
Shielding children from competition does not prepare them for adulthood.	.57	.41	.45
Fairness means letting people have equal opportunity, not guaranteeing equal outcome.	.45	.53	.46
Factor 3: Personal Whereewithal			
Anybody can get ahead in the world if they learn to play the game.	.76	.46	.57
Any goal can be achieved with enough hard work and talent.	.70	.62	.59
Right now, pretty much all Americans are free to live any kind of life they want.	.79	.74	.54
When it comes to challenges like discrimination, individuals just have to be tough enough to overcome them.	.82	.42	.60
I've benefited from working hard, so there's no reason others can't.	.86	.70	.59
If you're smart and strong enough, discrimination won't hold you back.	.84	.56	.62

(Continued)

Table 2. Continued

	CFA loadings			
	United States	Hong Kong	India	
A person's success in life is determined more by his or her personal efforts than by society.	.83	.67	.53	
Anyone who is willing to work hard can be successful in America.	.83	.51	.54	
Factor 4: Government Interference				
A problem with government social programs is that they get in the way of personal freedom.	.84	.63	.62	
The government is inefficient, and therefore should not interfere in the private sector.	.81	.54	.69	
The government often hurts individual ambition when it interferes.	.83	.70	.64	
The government does not have a right to take what I earn and give it to someone else.	.78	.68	.58	
Social programs sponsored by the government provide false incentives and unearned rewards.	.87	.57	.74	
Model fit indices	RMSE	SRMR	<i>p</i>	CFI
United States	.06	.05	<.001	.95
Hong Kong	.06	.08	<.001	.87
India	.06	.08	<.001	.88

Hypotheses Testing

In attempting to answer our original question—who is the neoliberal in Hong Kong, India, and the United States?—we found demographic, ideological, and psychological similarities and differences among those endorsing neoliberal beliefs. For example, we replicated Bay-Cheng et al.'s (2015) findings for SDO in our U.S. sample; in our Hong Kong and Indian samples, SDO also positively correlated with neoliberal beliefs (Hong Kong: $r = .33, p < .001$; India: $r = .25, p < .01$; United States: $r = .66, p < .001$). However, locus of control only correlated with the NBI in the U.S. sample ($r = -.28, p < .001$), but not in the Hong Kong ($r = -.09, p > .10$) and Indian ($r = -.06, p > .10$) samples (Hypotheses 1a and 1b), providing initial evidence that neoliberalism in a non-Western, less individualist, setting may align itself to psychological profiles that are more symptomatic of that setting. (See Table 3.)

Our second prediction (Hypothesis 2a) was partially supported by our data: Economic conservatism was correlated with neoliberal beliefs in all three samples

Table 3. Bivariate Correlations with NBI

	Age	Gender (female)	Education	Unemployed	SDO	(I-E) Locus of control	SECS social	SECS economic	SECS total	Inequality preference	Social benefit preference	Morality: Privileging self
Hong Kong	-.001	-.114	-.138	-.064	.334 ^{***}	-.087	.148 [†]	.256 ^{**}	.267 ^{**}	.083	-.057	.016
India	-.195 ^{**}	-.028	.108	-.159 [*]	.252 ^{**}	-.058	.328 ^{***}	.559 ^{***}	.517 ^{***}	-.024	-.343 ^{***}	.091
United States	-.092	-.028	.136 [†]	-.012	.655 ^{***}	-.279 ^{***}	.640 ^{***}	.681 ^{***}	.715 ^{***}	.219 ^{**}	-.171 [*]	.236 ^{**}
Combined	.063	-.147 ^{**}	.181 ^{**}	-.075 [†]	.540 ^{***}	-.287 ^{***}	.609 ^{***}	.663 ^{***}	.708 ^{***}	.114 ^{***}	-.298 ^{***}	.126 ^{**}

*** $p < .001$; ** $p < .01$; * $p < .05$; [†] $p < .10$.

(Hong Kong: $r = .26, p < .01$; India: $r = .56, p < .001$; United States: $r = .68, p < .001$) but so too was social conservatism—not only in the United States ($r = .64, p < .001$), but to a lesser extent in India ($r = .33, p < .001$), and marginally in Hong Kong ($r = .15, p < .10$). Potential explanations could be that in India and Hong Kong, mediated political discourse is packaging neoliberal economic beliefs with socially conservative beliefs (as can be seen in the United States), or that psychological “elective affinities” exert a slight pull in the direction of both sets of beliefs (though to a lesser extent than in the United States), or both. However, the low internal reliability of the SECS scale within our Hong Kong and Indian samples cautions against broad generalizations. Hypothesis 2b received support only in our U.S. sample: Neoliberal beliefs correlated significantly and positively with a preference for a more unequal society with low taxes and a minimal social safety net ($r = .22, p < .01$); but not in our Hong Kong ($r = .08, p > .10$) and Indian ($r = -.02, p > .10$) samples. Hypothesis 2c received support in our Indian ($r = -.34, p < .001$) and U.S. ($r = -.17, p < .001$) samples, but not in our Hong Kong ($r = -.057, p > .10$) sample, where NBI scores did not correlate with a preference for economic over social benefits in our policy, personal, and business vignette-dilemmas. These patterns suggest that neoliberal beliefs in Hong Kong and India may be particularly impactful on the realm of personal ethos or outlook on life, with fewer links to political-economic ideology and policy preferences.

Hypothesis 3, that participants with greater endorsement of neoliberal beliefs would choose self-interest over other interest in a series of moral vignette-dilemmas, received support only in our U.S. sample ($r = .24, p < .01$), but not our Hong Kong ($r = .02, p > .10$) and Indian ($r = .09, p > .10$) samples. However, Hypothesis 4 received broader support: self-maximizing self-interest correlated with neoliberal beliefs in all three samples (Hong Kong: $r = .36, p < .01$; India: $r = .64, p < .001$; United States: $r = .66, p < .001$), whereas self-priority (Hong Kong: $r = .09, p > .10$; India: $r = .69, p < .001$; United States: $r = .49, p < .001$) and self-comparative self-interest (Hong Kong: $r = -.05, p > .10$; India: $r = .65, p < .001$; United States: $r = .61, p < .001$) correlated with neoliberal beliefs in our Indian and U.S. samples, but not the Hong Kong sample. Prosocial other-interest was associated with neoliberal beliefs only in the Indian sample (Hong Kong: $r = .01, p > .10$; India: $r = .63, p < .001$; United States: $r = .11, p > .10$). These results show, again, that an individualist focus on the self (over others), where one prioritizes self-enhancement over prosocial behavior seems more consistent in the Western (United States) context than the (East) Asian Hong Kong and Indian contexts. This supports our aforementioned suggestion that neoliberalism sheds some of its individualist feathers when navigating in non-Western, Eastern cultures.

Greater narcissism was associated with neoliberal beliefs in all three samples (Hong Kong: $r = .28, p < .01$; India: $r = .14, p < .10$; United States: $r = .42, p < .001$), though only marginally among our Indian sample. Self-esteem positively

correlated with neoliberal beliefs in our Indian and U.S. samples, but evinced no statistically significant relationship in our Hong Kong sample (Hong Kong: $r = .10, p > .10$; India: $r = .40, p < .001$; United States: $r = .32, p < .001$). Hence, the idea that neoliberalism's individualistic, competitive, and meritocratic orientation, an ideology that favors the "best" and those viewing themselves as such, would be evidenced by a positive relationship between NBI on the one hand, and narcissism and self-esteem on the other hand was largely supported (Hypothesis 5).

Support for Hypothesis 6 was more mixed: In all three samples, agentic ("getting ahead") values were associated with neoliberal beliefs (Hong Kong: $r = .20, p < .05$; India: $r = .60, p < .001$; United States: $r = .57, p < .001$), but contrary to expectations, communal ("getting along") values were positively related to neoliberal beliefs in our Indian and U.S. samples, with no relationship in our Hong Kong sample (Hong Kong: $r = -.05, p > .10$; India: $r = .59, p < .001$; United States: $r = .27, p < .001$). The positive relationship in the Indian sample may be in line with previous findings supporting the expression of neoliberalism in a more culture-specific way (e.g., collectivist). However, that communal values also correlated positively in the U.S. sample goes against the individualist focus of neoliberalism in the West and begs the question why and in which situations, even in the West, neoliberal beliefs may enhance the desire to get along with others, or vice versa. (See Table 4.)

In line with the common conception that neoliberalism is a competition-enhancing ideology, Hypothesis 7 received unambiguous support, with neoliberal beliefs correlating positively in all three samples with insecure striving (Hong Kong: $r = .32, p < .001$; India: $r = .58, p < .001$; United States: $r = .55, p < .001$), along with all three subscales measuring different reasons for feeling the need to compete: losing out, being overlooked, and being actively rejected. Unexpectedly, neoliberal beliefs were moderately strongly associated with secure nonstriving in our Indian sample, and weakly in our U.S. sample (Hong Kong: $r = .07, p > .10$; India: $r = .64, p < .001$; United States: $r = .22, p < .01$). This partly supports the notion of culture-specific tendencies of neoliberalism.

As expected, participants in India and the United States with greater endorsement of neoliberal beliefs placed themselves higher on a power ladder, indicating a more dominant position in the socioeconomic hierarchy (Hypothesis 8). However, in our Hong Kong sample, there was no relationship (Hong Kong: $r = .02, p > .10$; India: $r = .27, p < .001$; United States: $r = .42, p < .001$). A possible explanation could be that only the Hong Kong sample consisted mainly of students, and therefore may have had less time to "find their place" in the world; the Hong Kong mean and variance were the lowest among the three samples.

Although our Indian sample evinced the strongest (by far) preference for lighter skin tone among our three samples, only among our Hong Kong sample was light skin tone preference positively associated with neoliberal beliefs (Hong Kong: $r = .17, p < .05$; India: $r = .09, p > .10$; United States: $r = .10, p > .10$). Hong Kong is widely considered to be a neoliberal capitalist city *par excellence*,

Table 4. Bivariate Correlations with NBI

	TSOR prosocial	TSOR self-maximizing	TSOR self-priority	TSOR self-comparative	NPI total	NPI leadership	NPI grandiose	NPI entitlement	Self-esteem	ACV agent	ACV communal
Hong Kong	.006	.360***	.092	-.053	.284**	.255**	.142	.220**	.096	.199*	-.052
India	.631***	.644***	.694***	.653***	.143†	.013	.134†	.099	.397***	.591***	.586***
United States	.110	.662***	.485***	.609***	.420***	.315***	.263***	.427***	.323***	.571***	.267***
Combined	.325***	.682***	.456***	.540***	.462***	.346***	.359***	.343***	.406***	.576***	.372***

	SIAS insecure striving	SIAS secure	SIAS losing out	SIAS overlooked	SIAS active rejection	Power ladder	Ethnic identification	Skin preference	Cohesive group preference
Hong Kong	.318***	.074	.205**	.228**	.213**	-.018	.041	.173**	.135
India	.581***	.637***	.258**	.248**	.206*	.274***	.247**	.087	.065
United States	.545***	.220**	.425***	.501***	.498***	.421***	.490***	.097	.214**
Combined	.574***	.364***	.300***	.387***	.408***	.433***	.455***	.165***	.244***

*** $p < .001$; ** $p < .01$; * $p < .05$; † $p < .10$

where colorism is still rampant (e.g., Wordie, 2017). The neoliberal focus on the entrepreneurial self—using the self as a commodity or asset—may explain why a stronger belief in neoliberalism goes hand in hand with a preference for lighter skin tones. A lighter skin tone may imply a higher position on the social hierarchy and provide better life opportunities. Hence, Hypothesis 9a receives support only in the Hong Kong sample. Contrariwise, Hypothesis 9b received support in our Indian and U.S. samples, but not in our Hong Kong sample (Hong Kong: $r = .04, p > .10$; India: $r = .25, p < .01$; United States: $r = .50, p < .001$). The positive association in our U.S. sample between neoliberal beliefs and ethnic identification parallels Dutt and Kohfeldt's (2019) finding in this issue. As hypothesized, majority group members identifying with their in-group may portray a form of ethnocentrism toward their own hegemonic group. As mentioned before, neoliberalism functions as a legitimizing ideology for status differences between groups (as evidenced by its consistent relationship with SDO) and portrays the current status quo as legitimate because it presumes that it is based in merit instead of being the result of unjust structural differences. A possible explanation for a lack of effect within the Hong Kong sample is that in Hong Kong ethnic identity is complicated by current tensions over seeing oneself as “Chinese” or “Hong Konger” (Ewing, 2018).

Hypothesis 10 was disconfirmed by our findings. In our Indian and Hong Kong samples, the correlation between neoliberal beliefs and a preference for a cohesive (“tight”) group was positive but nonsignificant; in our U.S. sample, it was positive and significant (Hong Kong: $r = .135, p > .10$; India: $r = .07, p > .10$; United States: $r = .21, p < .01$). Although contrary to our expectations that the individualistic tenor of the NBI would accord with a preference for uncohesive (“loose”) groups, as mentioned before, the United States is an outlier in which (neo)liberal economics and social conservatism are packaged together in both political discourse and survey results (e.g., Malka et al., 2017). In the United States, neoliberal beliefs are widespread among conservatives and the religious right, who generally prefer social cohesiveness because it buffers against threat and unpredictability (Bettache & Chiu, 2019; Jost et al., 2003). Indeed, Bettache and Chiu (2018; 2019) showed that their video measure consistently correlated positively with the endorsement of cohesiveness-enhancing social norms (e.g., a strict morality or authoritarianism) and conservatism. Moreover, this finding supports Azevedo et al.'s (2019) argument, that economic and social dimensions of ideology are not independent. Individuals who adhere to social conservatism (e.g., tight norms and traditionalism) are likely to embrace neoliberal economics. In other words, there seems to be an interesting contradiction within neoliberal ideology. On the one hand, it promotes economic individualism (e.g., entrepreneurialism, consumerism, and competition), yet it is endorsed mostly by people who generally oppose social deviancy and attempt to constrain personal freedoms (Bettache & Chiu, 2018, 2019).

Hypothesis 11 was partially supported. Mediation analyses, with the relationship between internal locus of control (lower I–E scores) and a preference for a

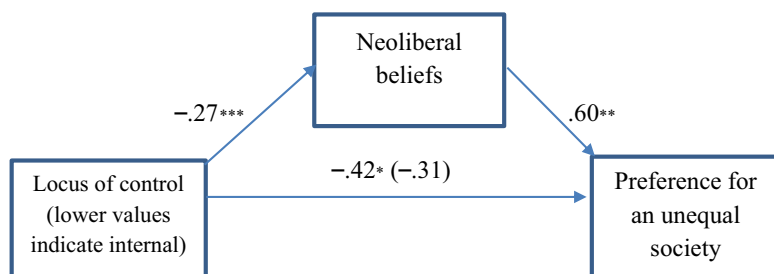


Fig. 2. Standardized regression coefficients for the relationship between internal locus of control and preference for an unequal society as mediated by neoliberal beliefs. (The standardized regression coefficient between internal locus of control and preference for an unequal society, controlling for neoliberal beliefs, is in parentheses.)

$^{***}p < .001$; $^{**}p < .01$; $^*p < .05$; $^{\dagger}p < .10$.

[Color figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

more unequal (and low-tax, minimal safety net) society mediated by endorsement of neoliberal beliefs, were only significant within our U.S. sample ($Z' = -2.23$, $p = .03$; Figure 2), but not in the Hong Kong ($Z' = -0.57$, $p = .56$), nor the Indian ($Z' = 0.23$, $p = .82$) samples. As we expected, neoliberalism seemingly provides legitimization for inequality and a minimal social safety net among Americans who believe one's outcomes in life are determined predominantly by one's own efforts. Yet, an internal locus of control was unrelated to both the endorsement of neoliberalism and a preference for an unequal society in both Hong Kong and India. This is an interesting finding because it suggests that neoliberalism and its strong focus on the self and individual responsibility may be particularly symptomatic of the Western (or United States) context. Indeed, compared to the United States, both India and Hong Kong are more collectivist-oriented societies where life outcomes are very much dependent on one's social standing within the larger collective (Hofstede, 1980). Hence, the cross-cultural expression of neoliberalism may show discrepancies where it comes to psychological constructs that are highly individualist in nature, such as an internal locus of control.

Using the results from our Hong Kong student sample as a guide, "the neoliberal" in Hong Kong has a more conservative economic ideology and a higher SDO; is more likely to endorse a self-maximizing theory of self-other relations (looking out for oneself); and is more narcissistic, focuses more on getting ahead than getting along, evinces a preference for lighter skin tones, and feels pressure to strive toward personal success driven by fears of losing out, being overlooked, and being rejected by others.

With our diverse but nonrepresentative Indian sample as a guide, "the neoliberal" in India is more likely to be younger, having less experience of India's preneoliberal, Gandhian socialist days, and is more likely to have a job. S/he has a more conservative economic and social ideology, and privileges narrowly economic

over social benefits. Psychologically, s/he has a higher SDO, identifies more with her/his own ethnicity, has higher self-esteem but is not appreciably more narcissistic, considers her/himself to be higher on the socioeconomic hierarchy, has a strong self-orientation but also cares about others doing well, equally values both getting ahead and getting along, and feels both the need to strive toward success driven by fears of losing out, being overlooked, and rejection, but also feels that if her/his efforts meet with failure, s/he will be loved, supported, and accepted by others.

These psychological tensions evoke ideological tensions in contemporary India (e.g., Ganguly-Scrase, 2003; Gopalakrishnan, 2006). For instance, the currently dominant political ideology and movement in India is “Hindutva,” that of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and its political (currently ruling) party, the Bharatiya Janata Party. In its beginnings, it was inspired by European fascism and looked to Christianity and Islam with a mixture of fear and a desire to emulate what seemingly made them strong: greater unity and equality than was found in Hindu culture (Jaffrelot, 1996). To achieve its ethnonationalist project, leaders in the RSS had to retain the support of the upper castes while at the same time bringing lower castes into a unified fold. Neoliberal ideology may provide an attractive compromise: in theory, offering the equality of individuals appealing to the underprivileged but ambitious, and in practice, maintaining and expanding divides of wealth and power.

Using the results of our diverse but nonrepresentative U.S. sample as a guide, “the neoliberal” in the United States has a more conservative economic and social ideology, identifies more with her/his ethnic group, has a greater preference for inequality, low taxes, and a minimal social safety net, and privileges economic over social benefits. S/he is more likely to decide moral questions in ways that maximize benefits to the self over others, has a higher SDO, a more internal locus of control, is more self-interested than other-interested, more narcissistic and has higher self-esteem, favors getting ahead more than getting along, prefers cohesive groups, and feels pressure to strive toward personal success driven by fears of losing out, being overlooked, and being rejected by others. To a lesser extent, s/he feels that if her/his efforts to attain success fail, s/he will still enjoy the support of others. Although “the neoliberal” in India mixes qualities of *homo economicus* and *homo reciprocans*, “the neoliberal” in the United States is a purer incarnation of the former.

Conclusion and Limitations

Studies of links between psychological traits and political-economic ideologies relate to what Jost et al. (2014) called the “chicken-and-egg” problem in political neuroscience and psychology. That is, what is causing what? Are gene–environment interactions causing the development of physiological and psychological traits that incline people toward adopting some ideological elements over others available in their ideational environment or ecology of information? Or

are certain political beliefs causing the development of those physiological and psychological traits that have been found to correlate with these beliefs? Or is the process bidirectional, with physiological and psychological traits influencing which ideas are adopted, and adopted ideas influencing the development of physiological and psychological traits?

The present study illustrates to what a limited extent this chicken-and-egg question has been answered. Correlations found between neoliberal beliefs and the psychological traits we investigated could be due to unidirectional causation in either of the two directions—gene–environment interactions producing psychological traits that incline people toward adopting neoliberal ideas in their environment, or neoliberal ideas being adopted and then influencing the development of corresponding psychological traits. Or, causation could be bidirectional, with traits such as narcissism and insecure striving making neoliberal ideas more attractive and likely to be adopted, and neoliberal ideas, once adopted as beliefs, influencing the development of a more narcissistic personality and insecure striving, that is, greater anxiety and fear at the prospect of failure. It seems easier to answer a question about *who* a neoliberal is, psychologically, than to answer *why*.

Part of the reason for this can be found in Gjorgjioska and Tomicic's (2019) analysis, in this issue, of neoliberalism's effects on academia. To uncover effects of the adoption of neoliberal ideas on the development of psychological traits would require decades-long investigations—something the political economy of universities currently disincentivizes. Although there have been fascinating and important studies measuring links between psychological traits in childhood and political ideology in adulthood, they are conspicuous in their rarity (Block & Block, 2006; Fraley, Griffin, Belsky, & Roisman, 2012; Lewis, 2018). We are aware of no studies attempting to measure the adoption and later (potential) psychological effects of ideology. In addition, future research would benefit from access to nationally representative samples—which, given the expense involved, can be considered another casualty of the political economy of universities and the neoliberal governments that (under)fund them.

Our results also gave a slight indication (below-threshold CFI) that future research might do well to modify the NBI scale, tailoring it for each culture studied. (Likewise, the SECS and SDO scales we used had poor or weak internal reliability among our Hong Kong and Indian samples; future research would do well to use better tailored variants.) Although our confirmatory factor analyses indicated that it held up surprisingly well for a scale designed for the U.S. cultural context, items could be redesigned to tap into the rhetoric and values in which neoliberal ideology is founded in different locales. For instance, questions about affirmative action could be replaced with questions concerning local debates around inequality and the policies proposed (or implemented) to ameliorate it. Knowledge about how neoliberal discourse manifests in a given culture can be applied directly, modifying items to evoke recurring themes and rhetoric, in the

way that “Anyone who is willing to work hard can be successful in America” evokes the trope of the self-made man in the U.S. context.

Additional cross-cultural research is needed into links between ideology and psychological traits. This is of theoretical interest, as findings of similar ideology–trait relationships across political and cultural contexts would suggest that these are tapping into features of our evolved psychology, now exaptations applying to very recent developments in our political-economic systems. Alternatively, markedly different patterns of ideology–trait relationships would indicate a greater influence of ideas on psychological development, bringing us closer to a resolution of the chicken-and-egg problem. Most importantly, this is of immediate social and political interest. Knowing the psychological traits that dispose people to accept one or another ideology can be useful in designing persuasive political appeals (e.g., Wolsko, Ariceaga, & Seiden, 2016). For those dissatisfied with neoliberalism and its economic, social, and psychological effects, knowing the psychological needs and dispositions of its adherents can be helpful in designing communicative strategies that effectively cross ideological divides. Attempts to do so can be tested, to find appeals that are most persuasive among those with neoliberal beliefs and the psychological traits that correlate with them (e.g., an argument that government funding of education, healthcare, and childcare provides a more meritocratic competitive environment, by eliminating unearned advantages from birth).

Finally, the suite of traits with which we found neoliberal ideology to be related adds to a psychological indictment of neoliberalism, in addition to the economic (aggravated wealth and income inequality and boom-and-bust cycles), ecological (runaway greenhouse gas emissions), and political (the “depoliticization” of economic policy, restricting electoral politics to debates over less impactful issues) problems associated with it. Although evidence from Hong Kong and India suggests that the spread of neoliberal ideology does not always produce myopically self-interested, other-disregarding dispositions, the weight of the psychological evidence compiled thus far does not put neoliberalism in a good light (see also Beattie, 2019). An ideology related to narcissism, SDO, insecure striving, agentic (“getting ahead”) values, and a self-regarding view of relationships cannot remain globally dominant without doing continued damage to our psychological, economic, ecological, and political well-being.

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